

LESSON 5 · ART SCHOOL, BUT DIY

Shading & Texture

How to use mark-making to convey surface quality, material, and tactile reality.

Overview

Once you understand value (Lesson 4), the next challenge is controlling the marks that create it. Shading isn't a single technique — it's a family of methods, each with a different character. Hatching creates structure and direction; blending creates smoothness and continuity; stippling creates granular, atmospheric texture. Knowing when to use each is as important as knowing how.

Texture adds the dimension of surface quality — the rough grain of wood, the cold sheen of metal, the soft diffusion of fabric. Rendering texture convincingly is what makes drawings feel tactile. You don't draw every fiber of the cloth — you identify the *behavior* of the surface and suggest it with a few well-placed marks.

CORE CONCEPTS

Hatching

A series of parallel lines used to build tone. Closer lines = darker value; wider spacing = lighter value. The direction of hatching lines is not arbitrary — they should follow the contour of the form (cross-contour hatching), wrapping around the surface to reinforce its three-dimensionality. Hatching that ignores form direction flattens the drawing.

Cross-Hatching

Two or more layers of hatching at different angles. The first layer builds the base value; subsequent layers darken specific areas and add textural complexity. Cross-hatching is powerful for deep shadows and rough surfaces. The angle between layers affects character: 45-degree crossings feel geometric; gentle curves feel organic.

Stippling

Building tone through dots of varying density. Dense clusters create dark areas; sparse dots create light areas. Stippling is slow but produces an atmospheric, grain-like texture that no other technique matches. It is often used in scientific and botanical illustration. Practice density control before attempting large stippled areas.

Blending

Smoothing pencil marks with a blending stump, tortillion, or finger. Creates soft, continuous gradients. Extremely effective for skin, smooth metal, and atmospheric backgrounds. The risk is over-blending — which destroys mark character and makes surfaces look plasticky. Reserve blending for truly smooth surfaces; let hatching carry everything else.

Cross-Contour Lines & Form Texture

Cross-contour lines are curved marks that wrap around a 3D form like latitude lines on a globe. Even when not explicitly drawn, the direction of every shading mark implies a contour. When hatching follows the surface direction, the form feels solid. When hatching runs against it (all horizontal marks on a sphere), the form flattens.

Identifying Surface Behavior

Before rendering any texture, ask three questions: (1) Is the surface hard or soft? (2) Is it smooth or rough? (3) How does it interact with light — does it have sharp highlights, or are they diffuse? The answers determine your approach: smooth metal needs clean gradients and crisp highlights; rough fabric needs broken edges and scattered marks.

DAILY EXERCISES

EXERCISE 1

Texture Swatch Library

- Fill one sketchbook page with 9 texture swatches: wood grain, stone, fabric, metal, glass, fur, paper, bark, leather.
- Each swatch should be roughly 5x5 cm. No reference — draw from memory first.
- Then redo from observation: find each material around you and study how light reveals its texture.
- Keep this page as a reference library for future drawings.

EXERCISE 2**Hatching Progression Sheet**

- Create a value gradient using only hatching (no blending): from white to 90% dark.
- Repeat with cross-hatching at three angle combinations: 30/90, 45/90, 45/15 degrees.
- Repeat with stippling: control density, not size — all dots the same size.
- Compare the three. Note which creates the smoothest gradient, which has the most texture character.

EXERCISE 3**Material Rendering Study**

- Set up three objects of contrasting materials: a metal spoon, a folded cloth, a wooden object.
- Draw all three in the same composition under a single lamp.
- Each object should use a different primary shading approach: smooth gradients for metal, directional hatching for cloth, mixed technique for wood.
- Take 60 minutes. Focus entirely on the difference in surface behavior — not on getting the proportions perfect.

CURATED FREE RESOURCES

Alphonso Dunn — Hatching & Cross-Hatching Mastery (Playlist)youtube.com/@AlphonsoDunn · Video Series

The definitive free resource on pen-and-ink hatching techniques. Watch the full playlist in order.

Circle Line Art School — Pen & Ink Techniquesyoutube.com/@circlelineartschool · Video Channel

Excellent tutorials covering hatching, stippling, and texture rendering in pen. Relaxed, easy to follow.

Ctrl+Paint — Texture & Surface Libraryctrlpaint.com/topics/texture · Course

Free library section on observing and rendering different surface textures for digital and traditional work.

Jazza — Shading Techniques for Beginnersyoutube.com/@JonathanJazza · Video

Comparative walkthrough of hatching, cross-hatching, blending, and stippling side by side.

Aaron Blaise — Fur, Hair & Organic Textureyoutube.com/@AaronBlaiseArt · Video

Disney animation veteran breaks down hair, fur, and complex organic textures with pencil and digital media.

Proko — Cross-Contour Lines & Form Textureyoutube.com/@Proko · Video

How cross-contour hatching wraps around form to create three-dimensionality.

Draw a Box — Organic Forms & Texturedrawabox.com/lesson/2 · Free Course

Structured exercises for applying texture to 3D forms using systematic mark-making.

Sinix Design — How to Render Anythingyoutube.com/@sinixdesign · Video

Framework for breaking down any surface into key visual properties and rendering it convincingly.

Line of Action — Daily Observational Practiceline-of-action.com · Tool

Free timed-practice tool. Use "Hands & Feet" or "Environments" modes for texture observation.

Krita — Free Digital Painting Appkrita.org/en/download · Tool (Free)

Professional free digital painting software. Explore texture digitally alongside traditional practice.

SKETCHBOOK PRACTICE

Every day: Fill half a page with hatching in a single direction. Then cross-hatch. Then stipple. Build tone in each. 10 minutes total.

Weekly: Pick one material from your environment and render a detailed close-up study — focus entirely on how that material catches and diffuses light.